

bargained for his time — three minutes per person, then down to two. It was all a bit chaotic. A volunteer looked aghast. But this was Neeraj Chopra, and everyone wanted a moment with him.

The 26-year-old came through one of the toughest fields to place himself on the podium.

"This is the greatest competition I've been a part of," he says at the press conference, and this is probably true. Fifth place here would have won gold in Tokyo. If Arshad's winning throw was an Olympic record, Neeraj's 89.45m is the biggest throw ever to have won an Olympic silver.

This medal is yet another point in favour of the argument that he is among the greatest of Indian sports. He has been on the podium of every competition he competed in over the last six years.

His medal is also the best result for an Indian at these Games; the other five medals won have all been bronze. Just like at the Tokyo Games, Neeraj has been the high point of the Indian performance in Paris. His silver medal is where the Indian campaign peaked. It was a remarkable achievement.

Anyone would have been happy. But not Neeraj.

He is the country's only Olympic champion in athletics. He's also the reigning world champion. Throughout his career, he has made achieving excellence look effortless and normal, rather than a rare feat that only a once-in-a-generation athlete can accomplish.

At his press conference, and earlier in the mixed zone, he expressed praise for his rival from Pakistan. He spoke about how God was with him for the previous ten encounters between the two, but how, on the biggest stage on earth, Arshad's talent and hard work made the difference.

He cracked a few self-deprecating jokes about his inability to translate his words accurately into English — a language he has become remarkably proficient in over the last three years — and about how he could make only one legitimate attempt (all his other throws were fouls). He even mentioned that the third-place finisher has the same set of injuries as he does.

He took time to give context to India's performance at the Games and shared his thoughts about wrestler Vinesh Phogat, who herself was in contention for a gold medal

but was disqualified after turning up 100 grams over the weight limit.

He credited her courage and mental strength. Everyone had their opinion on the matter, but Neeraj's was the one that mattered.

Everyone wanted to know what he thought about this issue. Just as they did in the early morning outside the Stade de France, everyone wanted a piece of him.

Neeraj has been giving away pieces of himself for a while now.

He has a silver medal but admits he is hurt because he hasn't been able to perform as well as he wanted.

He revealed that he has been carrying a groin injury for the last seven years — one year longer than his remarkable run of always finishing among the medals.

It's an injury that preys on his mind. He will go several months in the best shape of his career before



Throughout his career, Neeraj has made excellence seem like the default.

